

STEM4U — FTC Judging Prep Pack

Nail the pit interview and the judged awards · BIOBUZZ 2026–27 Award names/criteria follow the current Competition Manual (§ Awards). Confirm before your event.

How judging works

Judges review your **portfolio**, then visit your **pit** for a short interview (often ~5 minutes), and may watch you compete. They're deciding the **judged awards** — the ones you don't win by score. Be ready to talk clearly, include everyone, and back up claims with evidence.

The judged awards — and what each rewards

Award	What impresses the judges
Inspire	The best all-around team — strong robot and portfolio, judging, outreach, and Gracious Professionalism. The top honor.
Think	Your engineering process — how you designed, tested, and iterated (shown in the notebook/portfolio).
Connect	Connecting with the engineering community and planning for the team's future.
Innovate	A creative, unique design solution to a problem (with a working implementation).
Design	Robot design excellence — industrial design, function, and durability.
Motivate	A team that embodies FIRST — spreads enthusiasm, recruits, and shares the program.
Control	Excellence in software, sensors, and autonomous control.

The 60-second team pitch (memorize the shape, not a script)

"We're [team # and name] from [org]. This season our strategy is [1 line]. The part of our robot we're proudest of is [subsystem], because [the problem it solves and how we iterated to it]. Off the field, we [one real outreach story with a number]. We'd love to show you [the thing you want them to see]."

Common pit-interview questions — be ready

- Walk us through your **robot** and your **strategy**.
- Tell us about a **design that failed** and what you did about it.
- How is your **team organized** — who does what?
- What was your **hardest problem** this season and how did you solve it?
- Tell us about your **outreach** — who did you reach and what changed?
- How do you use your **engineering notebook**?
- How does your team practice **Gracious Professionalism**?

Do / Don't

Do: let **multiple students** speak (not one captain); point to evidence in the portfolio; be specific with numbers and stories; be honest about what didn't work; thank the judges. **Don't:** let mentors answer; memorize a rigid script; oversell or exaggerate; talk over teammates; go silent — if unsure, say how you'd find out.

Assign roles before judges arrive

- **Opener** — greets judges, gives the 60-second pitch.
- **Robot lead** — walks the robot + a failed-iteration story.
- **Team/outreach lead** — how the team runs + your impact story.
- **Software lead** — autonomous + sensors (Control award).
- **Everyone** — one thing each student can speak to, so the whole team is visible.

The single biggest win: **show iteration and include everyone.** Judges remember teams that clearly learned from failure and where every student had a voice.